Hemu slumped upon his howdah, unconscious.

It is a telling indictment of warfare in general that if the leader of a battle was killed, his army lost all interest in the fight. Thus, when Akbar and Bairam reached Panipat, they did not find a battle to join, but a victory to celebrate. Hemu's army had disintegrated like chalk to dust; his elephant Hawai, meandering off the battlefield, had been captured, and Hemu was in chains.[43]

The grocer who became a general, the shopkeeper who dreamt of empire, the champion of over twenty battles who now lay bleeding and breathing his last, was brought before Akbar, a boy who still needed his stirrups shortened to ride a horse. Bairam Khan did not – or could not – see the asymmetry. He, too, had lost his father young, and joined Babur's army when he was sixteen, only two years older than Akbar was now. He told the newly crowned padishah to execute his foe: it would be an act of 'holy combat', a blow for empire and for Islam.[44]

Looking at the man before him, with his horrible wound and his rasping breath, Akbar hesitated. He made excuses.

'I have already torn him to pieces,' he said. 'One day in Kabul I was practicing drawing . . . I drew a picture of a person with disjointed limbs.' When someone asked him what he was trying to draw, he said, 'It's a picture of Hemu.'[45]

It is impossible that Akbar had heard of Hemu until a few months before the man himself was brought before him. For Abul Fazl, this is, of course, the miracle of the drawing. There are other ways to look at it, too. A child drawing cartoonish scenes of graphic violence, as another might play with dolls by tearing their limbs apart. A boy inspired by stories of his father's enemies in a faraway land, mangling one of them on paper: I'll beat him, I'll kill him. A man, a little embarrassed by his adolescent inhibitions over spilling human blood, camouflaging the fact in stories.

A cacophony of voices rose to support Bairam's suggestion. Akbar must kill the enemy! Abul Fazl writes that the more they 'pressed him' to do it, the more Akbar resisted. Ferishta says that the boy compromised by touching Hemu with his sword. Some later historians, from Vincent A. Smith to Harbans Mukhia, believe that Akbar did, in fact, use his sword more forcefully.